

PROFILE

ADHIK KADAM

Peacebuilder | Social Entrepreneur

Founder, Borderless World Foundation

More than three decades of living, learning and serving in Jammu & Kashmir

JOINING HANDS. BUILDING BRIDGES.

RESCUE | REBUILD | REVIVE

HUMANITY BEYOND BOUNDARIES

Executive Profile

Adhik Kadam is a peacebuilder and social entrepreneur whose engagement with Jammu & Kashmir began in 1995, when he was an eighteen-year-old Political Science student from Pune. What started as an effort to understand conflict through the lived experiences of displaced families and border communities gradually became a lifelong commitment to children, women, healthcare, emergency response and community-led peacebuilding.

He is the Founder of Borderless World Foundation (BWF), an organisation built around a simple idea: human dignity must transcend geography, religion, region, gender, class and conflict. Its philosophy - Joining Hands, Building Bridges - combines immediate humanitarian response with long-term rehabilitation, education, healthcare, livelihoods and community ownership. Through BWF, he has helped develop sustained humanitarian interventions across Jammu, Kashmir, Ladakh and other underserved regions.

Human beings should never become prisoners of the borders created around them - or the borders we create within ourselves.

1995

JOURNEY BEGINS

6

RESIDENTIAL CENTRES

2,500+

GIRLS DIRECTLY SUPPORTED

1,100+

RETINAL SURGERIES

Milestones

YEAR	MILESTONE
1995	At 18, travels to Jammu; listens to displaced Kashmiri Pandit families and studies border realities in Rajouri and Poonch.
1997	First enters Kashmir Valley and begins living closely with local communities.
1999	Kargil War response: community kitchens and tutoring for children in temporary shelters around Gagangir and Sonamarg.
2002	Borderless World Foundation and first Basera-e-Tabassum home established in Kupwara.
2005	Kashmir earthquake response through community kitchens, relief mobilisation and humanitarian networking.
2009	Project FAH launched in Jammu for girls affected by displacement, border insecurity and severe vulnerability.
2014	Kashmir floods: community kitchens, 10 ambulances, around 120 doctors and medical response for more than four months.
2016	Eye-injury crisis: specialist mobilisation and 1,100+ free retinal surgeries. BWF also began expanding emergency medical services through Critical Care / ALS-BLS ambulances in collaboration with public health and security institutions.
Following years	Mobile Medical Units introduced to strengthen primary healthcare access in remote and underserved communities across Jammu & Kashmir and Ladakh, with the model later extending to other regions.
Today	Five Basera-e-Tabassum centres in the Valley plus FAH Jammu; 2,500+ girls directly supported; former residents now professionals, mothers, staff, directors, Board members and trustees.

The Years Before Kashmir

Discipline, Tradition and an Unexpected Turning Point

Adhik Kadam's childhood was shaped by two rigorous disciplines: traditional wrestling and music. Coming from a family rooted in Maharashtra's Varkari spiritual tradition, he grew up in an environment where devotion was connected with simplicity, discipline, community and service.

At the age of seven, Adhik entered a traditional wrestling akhada. For approximately ten years, until the age of seventeen, wrestling remained a rigorous part of his daily life. The akhada became one of his earliest schools of endurance, repetition, restraint and the ability to rise after falling.

Alongside wrestling, his parents encouraged him to learn the Pakhawaj/Mridangam, an instrument deeply associated with Maharashtra's devotional and Varkari musical traditions. Under the guidance of a Guru, he studied and practised the instrument systematically for nearly ten years.

Wrestling trained the body. Pakhawaj trained rhythm and listening. The Varkari tradition provided an inner foundation.

When an Injury Changed the Direction

During a wrestling match, Adhik suffered a fracture to his hand. The injury forced him to suspend wrestling for a prolonged period and also interrupted his regular Pakhawaj practice. What first appeared only as a setback created unexpected space for deeper study.

He became increasingly drawn to Political Science, the Constitution of India, Article 370, the political history of Jammu & Kashmir and the causes and consequences of conflict. But the more he read, the more he felt that books and newspapers could not fully explain how ordinary people actually lived inside conflict.

Political Science created questions. Jammu & Kashmir turned those questions into lived experience.

1995 - An Eighteen-Year-Old Student Arrives in Jammu

In November 1995, while still in the first year of his Political Science studies in Pune, Adhik travelled to Jammu. There was no NGO, no project, no funding and no institutional network. There were only questions.

For approximately four months, from November 1995 to February 1996, he travelled, observed and listened. In Jammu, he visited camps and settlements where displaced Kashmiri Pandit families were living. He met hundreds of people and listened to personal accounts of migration, fear, loss of home, disrupted livelihoods and the difficult process of beginning life again away from familiar surroundings.

Displacement was no longer a political term. It had a face, a family, a memory and a home someone could no longer return to.

During the same 1995-96 journey, his search for understanding took him towards Rajouri and Poonch, districts along the Line of Control. There he encountered communities for whom tension and cross-border shelling could enter directly into village life - affecting homes, education, livelihoods, movement and people's sense of security. These visits became part of the same early field study through which an eighteen-year-old student was trying to understand the human consequences of conflict beyond political theory.

Adhik wanted to enter the Kashmir Valley during this first journey as well, but the security situation prevented him from doing so. With examinations approaching, he returned to Pune. In November 1996 he came back, and in January 1997 he was finally able to enter the Valley.

This first journey also established the method that would later define Adhik's work: understanding communities by spending time among them rather than studying them from a distance. After entering the Kashmir Valley in January 1997, this became his way of life. He stayed with local families, ate with them, travelled with them and listened to their lives. In his early years he deliberately avoided creating distance through hotels or institutional comforts; people shared their food and homes with him.

Over time, people were no longer subjects of study. They became relationships. Those relationships slowly created a people-to-people, heart-to-heart connection during some of the most turbulent years in the Valley.

Trust in a conflict environment cannot be created through occasional visits. It is created through presence.

The Himalayan Valley and the Inner Discipline

For Adhik, Kashmir gradually became more than a geography associated with conflict. It was also a Himalayan civilisation shaped by centuries of spiritual inquiry - by Rishis, Sufis, saints, mystics and ordinary people carrying inherited wisdom.

Living in the Valley during periods of extreme turmoil created another kind of education. He learned the value of silence when argument could achieve little, patience when circumstances could not immediately be changed, listening when people carried pain, and trust when fear encouraged withdrawal.

His Varkari upbringing, later spiritual practice and the guidance of spiritual mentors strengthened an inner conviction that service could not be governed by fear, anger or identity. Even through periods of serious threats and hostility, he sought to respond through patience, conduct and continued presence rather than retaliation.

Courage without anger. Conviction without hatred. Service without discrimination. Faith without imposing it upon another.

1999 - The Kargil War

When the Kargil War erupted in 1999, Adhik was already working in Kashmir. Shelling and insecurity forced families from vulnerable areas to leave their villages and move towards safer locations.

In the Gagangir and Sonamarg areas, he encountered villagers living in temporary shelters, uncertain when they would be able to return home. Adhik worked alongside these displaced families, mobilising groceries, food grains and essential supplies and helping run community kitchens for months during the period of displacement.

When War Interrupted Childhood

Amid the immediate struggle for food and shelter, Adhik noticed another casualty of war: children had stopped going to school. Alongside relief work, he volunteered as a tutor for children living in temporary shelters, attempting to maintain some continuity in their education until families could return home.

Humanitarian response must protect not only life, but also the continuity of hope.

From Relief to Responsibility

The experience of war raised a deeper question: emergencies disappear from headlines much sooner than they disappear from people's lives. A community kitchen can answer today's hunger, but who remains when emergency relief ends? Who ensures a child returns to school, reaches adolescence safely and arrives at adulthood with dignity?

2002 - Borderless World Foundation

In 2002, that evolving responsibility took institutional form through the establishment of the Borderless World Foundation (BWF). The philosophy was expressed in four words: Joining Hands, Building Bridges.

BWF was never intended merely to become another organisation delivering charity. It represented a larger idea: to go beyond borders - not only geographical borders, but borders of religion, region, language, gender, class, prejudice, fear and the limitations human beings create within themselves.

Joining Hands. Building Bridges.

Basera-e-Tabassum

From Two Girls to Generations of Daughters

In 2002, the first Basera-e-Tabassum - “Abode of Smiles” - was established in Kupwara. It began with just two girls. The intention was never merely to create an orphanage; it was to create a home where girls affected by conflict, loss, displacement, economic hardship or difficult family circumstances could receive safety, affection, education and opportunity.

Over time, additional centres were established across the Kashmir Valley. Today, Basera-e-Tabassum operates through five centres in the Valley, complemented by FAH in Jammu.

5

BET CENTRES IN VALLEY

1

FAH IN JAMMU

2,500+

GIRLS DIRECTLY SUPPORTED

When Service Required Courage

Creating residential homes for vulnerable girls in a conflict environment was never going to be simple. Adhik was an outsider in many conventional senses - a young man from Maharashtra, from a different cultural and religious background, taking responsibility for girls in sensitive areas of Kashmir.

Questions arose. Rumours circulated. There were periods of social resistance and serious threats to his safety. In an ordinary environment, a rumour can damage a reputation. In a conflict environment, it can endanger a life.

He could have withdrawn. Instead, he chose to remain - and he did not leave the girls alone.

The Answer Was Presence

Adhik gradually understood that trust could never be demanded. It had to be earned. Families needed to remain connected. Neighbours needed to understand the homes. Teachers needed to participate. Local women needed to become part of the children's lives. Communities needed to see the work for themselves.

The response to suspicion therefore became transparency. The response to distance became participation. The response to rumours became years of consistent conduct. The response to fear became relationship. Slowly, what had once been questioned became familiar, and the homes became rooted within their communities.

Trust was not demanded. It was earned.

2005 - When the Earth Shook Kashmir

When the devastating 2005 Kashmir earthquake struck, Adhik and BWF worked among affected villages. Community kitchens were established and supported, essential resources were mobilised, and networks were created with organisations, volunteers and individuals capable of assisting affected communities.

The earthquake reinforced a principle that would remain central to Adhik's humanitarian method: no organisation can respond to human suffering alone. Sometimes an organisation's greatest strength is not what it owns, but its ability to connect need with resources, communities with institutions, and people willing to help with people who need them.

No organisation can respond to human suffering alone.

2009 - Project FAH, Jammu

Protection for Girls Affected by Displacement and Vulnerability

Years of working across Jammu & Kashmir exposed Adhik to another consequence of conflict: forced migration and the vulnerability that can follow it. Families affected by insecurity and conflict - including Kashmiri migrant families and communities from Ladakh, Kargil, Rajouri, Poonch and other border regions - often moved towards Jammu and other urban centres seeking safety and survival.

But reaching a city did not necessarily mean reaching security. Families sometimes arrived having lost homes, livelihoods, familiar networks and social support. Urban survival could be expensive and unforgiving, and within such fragile circumstances girls and women could become particularly vulnerable to interrupted education, unsafe accommodation, economic exploitation, abuse and, in extreme circumstances, trafficking.

The problem was not only displacement. It was what could happen after displacement.

A Safe Space in Jammu

In response, Project FAH was established in Jammu and successfully launched in 2009. FAH was conceived as a safe residential and developmental space for girls affected by displacement, border insecurity, conflict and severe socioeconomic vulnerability.

To ensure that displacement did not become exploitation.

Girls from diverse communities and geographies could find a protected environment along with education, care, guidance, skills and pathways towards independent adulthood. FAH embodied a principle central to BWF: human suffering cannot be divided by community. A vulnerable girl is first a child in need of safety; her religion, region or social identity cannot determine whether she deserves protection.

A City Can Be a Refuge - and Also a Risk

One insight behind FAH was that migration towards a city is often mistaken for automatic improvement. A family escaping insecurity may reach physical safety but encounter poverty. A child escaping conflict may lose education. A woman escaping one form of insecurity may enter another form of vulnerability.

Safety must be accompanied by stability. Stability must be accompanied by education. Education must lead towards dignity and opportunity.

2014 - The Kashmir Floods

From Survivor to Responder

In September 2014, catastrophic floods engulfed large parts of the Kashmir Valley. This time, Adhik was not initially outside the disaster trying to enter it. He was caught inside it.

As floodwaters overwhelmed neighbourhoods and disrupted food, communication, transport and healthcare, Adhik himself became stranded. For approximately three days, he remained caught in the flood situation with virtually no access to food. With assistance during rescue operations, including support from the Indian Army, he eventually reached safety.

He was rescued from the flood. Then he returned to serve those still inside it.

When Survival Turned into Service

BWF began establishing and supporting community kitchens at multiple locations. Families needed food, blankets, warm clothing, medicines and everyday necessities that had disappeared beneath the floodwater.

Then came the healthcare challenge. Ten ambulances were mobilised from Maharashtra. Around 120 doctors were mobilised over time to serve affected communities. Medical teams worked through camps and outreach interventions across flood-affected areas for more than four months.

10

AMBULANCES

~120

DOCTORS MOBILISED

4+ months

MEDICAL RELIEF

Rescue -> Food -> Healthcare -> Relief -> Recovery

2016 - Restoring Sight in a Time of Crisis

During the civil unrest of 2016, Kashmir experienced an extraordinary medical emergency as large numbers of people suffered serious eye injuries from pellet guns. Hospitals encountered complex ocular trauma and retinal injuries carrying the risk of permanent visual impairment.

For Adhik and BWF, the question was humanitarian rather than political: a human being was losing sight. That was enough to act.

If the patient cannot reach the specialist, the specialist must reach the patient.

BWF reached out to leading ophthalmologists and helped facilitate specialist medical teams to travel to Srinagar. Among those who responded was renowned vitreoretinal surgeon Padma Shri Prof. Dr. S. Natarajan, along with other specialists. They worked alongside ophthalmologists and medical teams at SMHS Hospital, Srinagar, undertaking complex retinal procedures.

The intervention contributed to more than 1,100 free retinal surgeries. Visiting specialists also worked with local doctors, strengthening knowledge and capacity to manage complex ocular trauma in the future.

1,100+

FREE RETINAL SURGERIES

SMHS

HOSPITAL COLLABORATION

Capacity

LOCAL SKILLS STRENGTHENED

The crisis and BWF's role in facilitating specialist medical visits also received international media attention, including coverage by The New York Times. For Adhik, however, the larger significance was that doctors travelled across India to operate on strangers, Kashmiri doctors worked beside visiting specialists, and civil society created the bridge.

In a moment defined by conflict, the response was defined by humanity.

From Crisis Response to Permanent Systems

Repeated emergencies taught Adhik that humanitarian response could not stop with relief. A community kitchen answers today's hunger. An ambulance answers today's emergency. A medical camp answers today's illness. But sustainable humanitarianism must always ask: what happens tomorrow?

This thinking helped BWF move towards permanent systems - residential care, education, higher education, emergency medical services, Mobile Medical Units, women's livelihoods, community healthcare, skills and vocational development, and local capacity building.

The crises were not separate from the BWF story. They helped shape the institution it became.

BWF subsequently introduced Mobile Medical Units to strengthen primary healthcare access in remote and underserved communities across districts of Jammu & Kashmir and Ladakh. The model takes doctors, basic diagnostics, medicines, preventive care and health awareness closer to communities for whom distance, terrain and limited local facilities can otherwise delay treatment. The approach later expanded to other underserved regions as well.

Mobile Medical Units - Taking Primary Healthcare to Remote Communities

As BWF moved from episodic relief towards stronger healthcare systems, it began participating in efforts to improve emergency medical infrastructure by mobilising and donating Critical Care / ALS-BLS ambulances for service through District Hospitals and in collaboration with institutions including the Indian Army and BSF. The objective was to strengthen the chain between remote communities, first response and definitive medical care.

Critical Care Ambulances and Emergency Medical Services

HEALTHCARE INFRASTRUCTURE

Kashmir LifeLine

Years spent travelling through remote communities exposed Adhik to another inequality: people could lose their lives not because treatment did not exist, but because it could not reach them in time. Mountains, snow, distance, difficult roads and delayed emergency response could determine whether someone survived.

Geography should never decide whether someone lives or dies.

DALPARI

Communities living within and around Srinagar's Dal Lake presented another unusual challenge. Road-based medical services could not easily reach families living across its islands and waterways. BWF responded by taking healthcare to the water through DALPARI, its floating Mobile Medical Unit, bringing primary healthcare closer to otherwise difficult-to-reach communities.

If people cannot reach healthcare, healthcare must find a way to reach people.

Women as Builders of Peace

Decades of experience convinced Adhik that sustainable peace cannot be built without women. Through initiatives including Rah-e-Niswan and other skill and livelihood programmes, BWF has worked to create economic and social opportunities for women and young girls.

But livelihood is only part of the story. An educated and economically secure woman strengthens her family. A confident woman changes how daughters perceive themselves. A mother shapes another generation.

Women are not merely beneficiaries of peace. They are among its most powerful builders.

Six Homes - One Long-Term Commitment

What began with two girls in Kupwara in 2002 gradually grew into a network of homes. Today, Basera-e-Tabassum has five centres in the Kashmir Valley, alongside FAH in Jammu.

Together, these residential initiatives have directly supported more than 2,500 girls through lodging and boarding, education, healthcare, higher education, skills and vocational training, career development, employment, social integration, marriage support where relevant, and long-term settlement within their communities.

5

BET CENTRES

1

FAH JAMMU

2,500+

GIRLS DIRECTLY BENEFITED

From Children in Care to Leaders of Change

Some girls entered BWF homes when they were only one to five years old. They were nurtured through childhood, went to school, entered colleges and universities, acquired professional qualifications and skills, and gradually became independent adults.

Today, former girls supported through BWF are working as doctors, engineers, lawyers, nurses, teachers, accountants, government employees, software engineers, corporate HR professionals, insurance professionals, entrepreneurs, writers and journalists, among many other professions. Some own businesses and shops. Many have become important breadwinners for their families.

Others have married, built families and returned with dignity and respect to the communities from which they came. Their success cannot be measured only by professional designation. Vulnerability did not become their permanent identity.

The real measure is not how many girls entered the homes. It is who they became.

Returning to the Community

Basera-e-Tabassum and FAH were never intended to permanently separate girls from society. The purpose was to enable them to return stronger. Today, former residents are professionals, entrepreneurs, neighbours, wives, mothers and respected members of their communities.

They are silent messengers of peace.

Motherhood as Silent Peacebuilding

Among the most profound outcomes is one that conventional impact indicators rarely capture. Many former girls are today mothers. A woman who has personally travelled from vulnerability to dignity carries that experience into the family she creates.

She can raise children with education, security, empathy, confidence and respect for others. In this sense, former BWF girls participate in peacebuilding in perhaps its quietest form - through motherhood. A peaceful society is not created only through agreements between institutions; it is also created in homes, through the values passed from one generation to another.

Peace can be inherited - when one generation chooses not to pass fear into the next.

From Beneficiary to Breadwinner

Many girls who once required financial support are today supporting their own families. The direction of assistance has reversed. They educate siblings, care for parents, contribute to household expenses, build businesses, raise children and sometimes employ others.

The objective is not to create beneficiaries. The objective is to create capability.

When the Supported Become the Support System

Perhaps the most remarkable transformation is taking place within BWF itself. Many former residents have chosen to return to the organisation that once supported them - but from the other side of the relationship. Today, more than 90% of the staff associated with the girls' homes are women who themselves once received support through the programme. They understand what it feels like to arrive as a child: uncertainty, loneliness, adolescence, family relationships, dreams, disappointments and the difficult transition towards independence.

When a newly admitted child looks at these women, she does not simply see a staff member. She sees her own possible future.

From Resident to Director - From Beneficiary to Trustee

The transformation has moved beyond employment. Former girls are increasingly assuming senior management, director-level, leadership and decision-making responsibilities within BWF. Some have become Board members and trustees, helping govern the institutions that once supported them.

The organisation is gradually moving from “We work for the girls” to “The girls lead the work.”

The Circle of Transformation

CHILD Protection	STUDENT Education	PROFESSIONAL Independence	BREADWINNER Family support
CITIZEN Community	PEACE MESSENGER Trust	CAREGIVER Next generation	TRUSTEE Custodianship
<i>This is not simply rehabilitation. This is generational transformation.</i>			

BWF Is Not Just an Organisation

It Is a Vision of Becoming Borderless

The evolution of these girls reveals the deeper meaning of Borderless World Foundation. Being borderless is not merely about crossing geographical boundaries. There are borders of religion, region, language, gender, class, prejudice, fear and limitations within ourselves.

There is also another subtle border in conventional humanitarian work: the border between the giver and the receiver. One person is called the benefactor and another the beneficiary. But when yesterday's beneficiary becomes today's caregiver, when the resident becomes the director and the child once protected becomes the trustee, that border disappears.

There are no longer people permanently giving and receiving. There are human beings carrying responsibility forward.

Two Histories - One Humanitarian Response

There is a deeper symmetry in Adhik's journey. It began in 1995 by listening to displaced Kashmiri Pandit families in Jammu. Later he entered the Kashmir Valley and spent decades living and working among local communities. Basera-e-Tabassum grew across the Valley; FAH developed in Jammu to respond to girls from migrant, displaced, border and economically vulnerable families from Kashmir, Ladakh, Kargil, Rajouri, Poonch and beyond.

A child's right to safety cannot depend upon the identity into which she was born.

Humanitarianism Without Identity

More than three decades in Jammu & Kashmir have taught Adhik that humanitarianism loses its meaning when it begins deciding who deserves compassion. A sick person is a patient. A vulnerable child is a child. A displaced family needs shelter. A hungry family needs food. A person facing blindness needs a doctor.

Religion, politics, language, region or identity cannot determine the value of someone's suffering.

Serve first. Listen before judging. Build relationships before institutions. Never allow identity to become a reason for withholding compassion.

From Charity to Dignity

Adhik does not believe humanitarian work should create permanent dependency. Its ultimate purpose should be to progressively make dependency unnecessary.

Sympathy → **Participation**

Dependency → **Capability**

Relief → **Rehabilitation**

Beneficiary → **Stakeholder**

Vulnerability → **Dignity**

Suspicion → **Trust**

Isolation → **Connection**

Division → **Dialogue**

Recipient → **Leader**

Conflict → **Human Relationship**

Dignity is greater than charity.

A Humanitarian Pattern Emerged

Across three decades, the circumstances changed dramatically. But a pattern remained.

PERIOD	CONTEXT	RESPONSE
1995-96	Jammu, Rajouri & Poonch	Listening -> Understanding displacement -> Border realities
1997	Kashmir Valley	Living with communities -> Relationships -> Trust
1999	Kargil War	Displacement -> Community kitchens -> Education
2002	Basera-e-Tabassum	Protection -> Education -> Long-term rehabilitation
2005	Earthquake	Disaster -> Community kitchens -> Resource mobilisation
2009	FAH Jammu	Displacement -> Protection -> Prevention of exploitation
2014	Kashmir Floods	Survival -> Relief -> Ambulances -> Doctors -> Recovery
2016	Eye Injury Crisis	Specialists -> Surgery -> Local capacity building
Following years	Healthcare infrastructure	Critical Care Ambulances -> Mobile Medical Units -> Remote primary care
Today	Institutional continuity	Professionals -> Mothers -> Leaders -> Directors -> Trustees

Be present. Listen. Respond to what people actually need. Mobilise what you do not have. Connect people who can help. Build local capacity. Remain after attention moves elsewhere.

Building Bridges in a Conflict Landscape

Across more than three decades, Adhik's work has brought together people and institutions that might otherwise rarely find themselves on the same side of a story: children and communities, teachers and doctors, civil society and administration, humanitarian organisations and security institutions, corporate partners and remote villages, and people carrying different religious, cultural and political experiences.

The objective was never to make everyone think alike. It was to discover something around which people could still stand together: human dignity.

Peace is not merely the absence of violence. Peace is the presence of trust.

Impact Beyond Numbers

Numbers establish scale, but they cannot completely describe transformation. The deeper impact is a displaced child continuing to learn during war; a little girl arriving frightened and years later becoming an educated professional; a family receiving a hot meal after losing its home; a doctor travelling across India to save the eyesight of someone he has never met; a woman becoming economically independent; a remote patient receiving healthcare at the doorstep; a daughter becoming a breadwinner; a former resident becoming a mother; a beneficiary becoming a manager; and a girl who once needed an institution becoming a trustee responsible for its future.

These are not simply stories of beneficiaries. They are stories of human possibility.

National and International Engagement

Adhik has shared experiences from his grassroots humanitarian journey through academic institutions, conferences and leadership platforms in India and internationally. His engagements have included platforms associated with Stanford University, the University of California Berkeley, Princeton University, TED/TEDx forums, Rotary platforms, the National Conference on Social Innovation and other academic and civil-society institutions. He has also been recognised as an INK Fellow.

What he carries to such forums is not simply theory about conflict resolution, but lived experience: what it takes to remain, to earn trust, to build institutions across social boundaries and to turn humanitarian service into community ownership.

Selected Awards and Recognitions

CNN-News18 Indian of the Year	Social Change
Rotary Humanity Hero Award	2020
Mother Teresa Award	2010
Youth Icon of the Year	Maharashtra Times / The Times Group
Spirit of Mastek Award	Mastek Foundation
ICA Award	2016
Savitri Sanman	2016
NBC Award	2017

Recognition does not complete responsibility. It enlarges it.

Rescue • Rebuild • Revive

RESCUE

Stand beside people when life, dignity or opportunity is under immediate threat.

REBUILD

Create education, healthcare, shelter, skills and community systems through which people can reconstruct their lives.

REVIVE

Restore confidence, dignity, relationships and hope until people are capable of shaping their own futures.

RETURN

Experience has revealed a fourth stage: people return to society not as permanent victims, but as citizens, professionals, breadwinners, parents, leaders and changemakers. Some return to BWF itself - not to receive, but to give.

The deepest humanitarian journey is not complete until the person once supported can support another.

A Different Understanding of Peace

After more than three decades inside a conflict landscape, Adhik's understanding of peace has become both simpler and deeper. Peace begins when a child feels safe, when education continues despite war, when somebody feeds a displaced family without asking who they are, when a woman becomes independent, when a doctor treats a stranger, when people of different identities cooperate around human suffering, when somebody once suspicious becomes a partner, when a mother raises another generation without passing inherited fear into it, and when yesterday's beneficiary becomes tomorrow's trustee.

Peace is not merely the absence of violence. Peace is the presence of trust.

The Real Legacy

Every founder eventually has to confront a profound question: what should remain when I am no longer here? Buildings can age. Projects can end. Funding cycles change. Awards become memories. Organisations themselves evolve. But values can travel from one generation to another.

At BWF, that transition has already begun. Girls who once received care are caring for others. Girls who once needed financial support are supporting families. Girls who once needed decisions made for them are making decisions. Girls who once needed an institution are managing it. Some are helping govern it.

The strongest institution may not be one permanently dependent upon its founder, but a generation capable of carrying its values beyond him.

The Hand That Was Once Held

Perhaps the entire journey of Basera-e-Tabassum and FAH can be expressed through one simple image. A little girl arrives. Someone extends a hand. She holds it. She grows, learns and becomes strong enough to walk independently. Years pass. Another little girl arrives, frightened and uncertain. A woman extends her hand - and this time, the woman offering that hand is the girl who once needed somebody else's.

The hand that was once held becomes the hand that holds another.

That is more than child welfare. More than education. More than rehabilitation. More than empowerment. That is legacy.

The Man Behind the Mission

Peacebuilder. Social entrepreneur. Founder. These describe aspects of Adhik Kadam, but perhaps his journey describes him better than any title can.

A seven-year-old boy entered an akhada and learned discipline. He spent a decade learning the rhythm of Pakhawaj under a Guru. An injury interrupted both practices. Political Science created questions. At eighteen, those questions brought him to Jammu. He listened to displaced Kashmiri Pandit families, travelled towards Rajouri and Poonch, entered the Kashmir Valley and began living with its people.

During war, he helped feed displaced families and taught their children. He created a home beginning with two little girls. When an earthquake struck, he worked among devastated communities. He created FAH for girls whose displacement and vulnerability could expose them to exploitation. When catastrophic floods engulfed Kashmir, he became caught in the disaster himself - and after reaching safety, returned to serve others. When young people faced blindness, he helped bring specialist doctors to Kashmir. When suspicion, resistance and threats challenged his presence, he stayed.

And through all of it, generations of girls continued growing within homes built around one enduring promise: You will not be abandoned.

Those girls became students. Students became professionals. Professionals became breadwinners. They became wives and mothers. They returned to their communities. They became silent messengers of peace. Some returned to BWF and became caregivers, managers, leaders, directors, Board members and trustees.

The work stopped belonging to the founder alone. It began belonging to the people for whom it had been created.

Somewhere along the same journey, Kashmir ceased to be simply a place where Adhik worked. It became part of who he was.

Change Begins With Me

Change does not always begin with governments, institutions or extraordinary resources. Sometimes it begins when one person refuses to look away: one child, one meal, one classroom, one family, one home, one patient, one doctor, one ambulance, one village, one relationship, one bridge - and then another.

But the deepest change does not end with me. It travels from one person to another, from one community to another, from one generation to the next. Eventually, the hand that once received becomes the hand that gives.

CHANGE BEGINS WITH ME.

ADHIK KADAM

Founder, Borderless World Foundation

Peacebuilder | Social Entrepreneur

JOINING HANDS. BUILDING BRIDGES.

RESCUE | REBUILD | REVIVE

DIGNITY BEYOND CHARITY. • HUMANITY BEYOND BOUNDARIES.